

They Aren't Just Scholars

Jews Have Excelled at Athletics, Too

One of the best-kept secrets has been the record of excellence of Jews in all kinds of sports, especially the American variety. The authoritative reference work in this area is *The Encyclopedia of Jews in Sports*, by Postal and Silver.

Their painstaking and comprehensive research was inspired in large part by the myth that Jews excelled much better in intellectual activities than in physical competition. Like all myths, this contains a kernel of truth. It is true that the exemplar of excellence in the Jewish community has been the scholar and the brilliant, lucid mind. Victories in dialectical debate have been relished more than conquests in the sports arena. The figure of a Jew bent over a folio of the Talmud in concentrated and pious study is better known than the exploits of Israelis in athletic competition.

When Shlomo Glickstein of Israel recently upset a more famous, seeded player at Wimbledon, many so-called experts were amazed that, to use a paraphrase, out of Zion should come the prowess of a Jew on the tennis court rather than his ability to deal with the intricacies of Rabbinic law.

However, whatever lack of achievements Jews have in sports — and I shall show that this is not at all true — cannot be attributed to any inherent ineptitude, but rather to cultural and historical circumstances, just as Jews in Israel have shown the world that they can be good farmers as well as successful merchants.

IN THE FIRST PLACE, Jews for almost 2000 years were required to live in restricted ghettos where lack of open spaces for outdoor games compelled them to engage in more sedentary pursuits. Secondly, Jewish communities usually found themselves between two opposing forces at war with one another, and thus they learned the evils of violence and brutality. (This was why no sacred altar could contain an element of iron, the symbol of war.)

However, more than this was the real fear of their leaders, the Rabbis, that to engage in athletic spectacles would lead to idolatry. In fact, the contests in the Greek and



Harold L. Gelfman

Roman stadia were religious in nature, dedicated to the gods. Moreover, Jews feared that the body and its needs would become far more important than intellectual and spiritual activities. To be sure, the desired balance between the physical and spiritual or intellectual was sometimes upset. And that is why some of the early Zionist leaders, organizers of the Jewish Olympics called the Macabiads, said: "We must again create a strong, muscular Judaism ... For us Jews sport has great educational significance."

THE TRUTH OF the matter is that from Biblical days to the present, Jews have not only been interested in athletic activity (even against the wishes of the Rabbis), but can boast of achievements and champions in almost every area of athletic competition. I shall never forget listening with my father, a traditional Jew, on the radio to the boxing exploits of Benny Leonard, Lew Tendler, "Kid" Kaplan, and other Jews, who became champions. I remember that in the largest Jewish city in the world, New York, Jews were not particularly enthused over the game of baseball until Manager John McGraw of the old New York Giants placed his confidence in Andy Cohen to fill the shoes of Rogers Hornsby, an impossible task. Then they filled the Polo Grounds whenever the Giants were in town.

To continue my nostalgia, I recall the Saturday evenings when we went to the YMHA (the Young Men's Hebrew Association) to see Nat Holman, "Mr. Basketball," of the original Celtics and now in the Basketball Hall of Fame; "Red" Auerbach, regarded as the great-

est professional basketball coach of all time; and other Jewish players from the famed teams at City College of New York and New York University. In football I read avidly about University of Michigan quarterback Benny Friedman, University of Pittsburgh's Marshall Goldberg, and Columbia's Sid Luckman, a member of football's college and professional Halls of Fame, who gave both non-Jews and Jews thrills on the gridiron on Saturday afternoons. I attended Brown University, where the "Iron Men" of 1926 included such Jewish stalwarts as Dave Mishel and the Cornsweet brothers. All of these performers and their records are meticulously delineated in Postal's and Silver's *Encyclopedia* (which has been up-dated since it was published in 1965).

THUS THE JEW, still deeply committed to the pursuit of intellectual and moral excellence, can yet be proud of his athletic heritage. There is the story told that more than 60 years ago, Dr. Solomon Schechter, head of the Jewish Theological Seminary of America, after examining a prospective candidate for the rabbinate, said, undoubtedly in jest: "Unless you can play baseball, you'll never get to be a Rabbi in America." Jews no longer frown on sports (if they ever have), and I suspect that one of the greatest challenges to Rabbis when they try to preach to their congregants on the Day of Atonement, which usually occurs during the World Series, is the interest in the score on that holiest of days.

Rabbi Harold Gelfman was for many years the spiritual leader of Temple Beth Israel in Macon. Now retired, he remains active in many phases of religious and community life, including the annual Institute of Religion, which he founded 12 years ago. Comments or questions about the Jewish faith or about subjects discussed in his columns may be addressed to him in care of The Macon Telegraph and News, P.O. Box 4167, Macon, Ga. 31213.

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